leaders, including Nehru, for personalizing foreign policy and for not developing and institutionalizing ‘strategic thinking, policy formulation and implementation’.[7] Subrahmanyam asserts that in matters of national security India followed the instincts of its leader rather than practising democracy in debating and determining policy. ‘Monocracies of all prime ministers of India from Jawaharlal Nehru to Atal Bihari Vajpayee in matters of national security appears to be largely due to this absence of strategic culture and tradition,’ [8] he wrote. To some extent this remains true to this day. Despite the creation of a National Security Council with a national security adviser and secretariat, India’s strategic decision-making process is still centred on the personality of the prime minister.

Jaswant Singh criticized Nehru for simply managing a system of external relations inherited from the British instead of defining clear underlying principles for India’s foreign policy. This criticism contrasts with the view that Nehruvianism represented a strategic vision for India. The 1998 presidential address spoke of the need to follow the path laid down by Mahatma Gandhi and Nehru, of India recovering ‘her traditional, historical place in the vanguard of human civilization’.[9] By then thirty-four years had passed since Nehru’s death and a half-century had gone since Gandhi’s assassination. Critics such as Jaswant Singh saw much of Nehru’s contribution to India’s foreign policy as grandiloquence rather than substantive strategic decisions.

High-sounding oratory has definitely been a strong feature of India’s approach to international relations. The 2003–04 presidential addresses to parliament talked about India forging ahead in the world by ‘drawing on the strength of our civilizational and historical ties with countries across the globe’. Ignoring the large number of poor in the country, the huge gap in GDP and other indicators with China and the serious lag in maintaining a modern military force, India’s president declared the twenty-first century as